

Indicator indicator

Greater honeyguide



Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Length 8 in (20 cm)
Weight 1¼ oz (50 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



The greater honeyguide is famous for guiding humans and animals—such as honey badgers—to wild bees’ nests. Once the nest has been broken open, the honeyguide flies down to it to feed. Apart from beeswax and bees, this bird also feeds on ants, termites, other insect larvae, and even the eggs of other birds. The greater honeyguide is a brood parasite and does not build its own nest. Nestlings have hooked bills with which they kill the nestlings of the host.



streaked wings

Melichneutes robustus

Lyre-tailed honeyguide



Location C. Africa

Length 3¾ in (9.5 cm)
Weight 2 oz (55 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



The lyre-tailed honeyguide has a lyre-shaped tail and brownish plumage with white markings on its outer feathers. It inhabits lowland and low mountain forests and is also found

in coffee plantations. Unlike the greater honeyguide (see left), this species is not known to lead other animals to bees’ nests. It is best known for its spectacular flight displays that take place all year round. During these displays, performed by both sexes, the bird flies high above the forest, then descends swiftly in a zigzag or spiral flight. The sound heard during the flights is probably produced by the air passing through the tail feathers. This unusual behavior is associated with feeding sites (bee hives). This honeyguide feeds mainly on beeswax, but also hunts insects in the air. Like the greater honeyguide, it does not build a nest, and probably parasitizes barbets.

Aulacorhynchus prasinus

Emerald toucanet



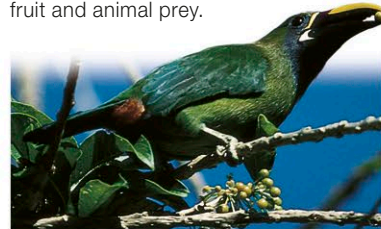
Location Mexico, S. Central America, W. South America

Length 12 in (30 cm)
Weight 5¼ oz (150 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Toucanets are medium-sized members of the toucan family with relatively modest-sized bills. This species is an upland bird typically found in mountain forests. It lives in pairs and

small groups, nesting and roosting in holes. Noisy groups may form in fruiting trees. The call is loud and varied, and includes croaking sounds as well as imitations of many local species of birds. The long, black and yellow bill, white at the base, helps this toucanet reach for fruit and animal prey.



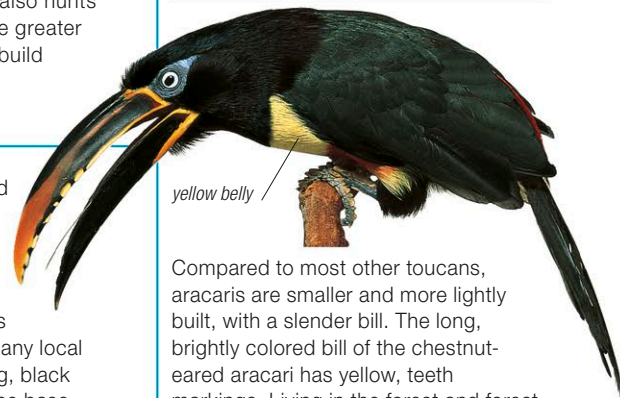
Pteroglossus castanotis

Chestnut-eared aracari



Location N. to C. South America

Length 13–16 in (33–40 cm)
Weight 10½ oz (300 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Compared to most other toucans, aracaris are smaller and more lightly built, with a slender bill. The long, brightly colored bill of the chestnut-eared aracari has yellow, teeth markings. Living in the forest and forest edge, this bird may be seen restlessly hopping through the tree canopy. It usually occurs in small groups that roost huddled in tree holes and hunt for insects and other small animals together, large flocks sometimes gathering at fruiting trees. Paired birds feed and preen each other. Like other toucans, the chestnut-eared aracari has an undulating flight.

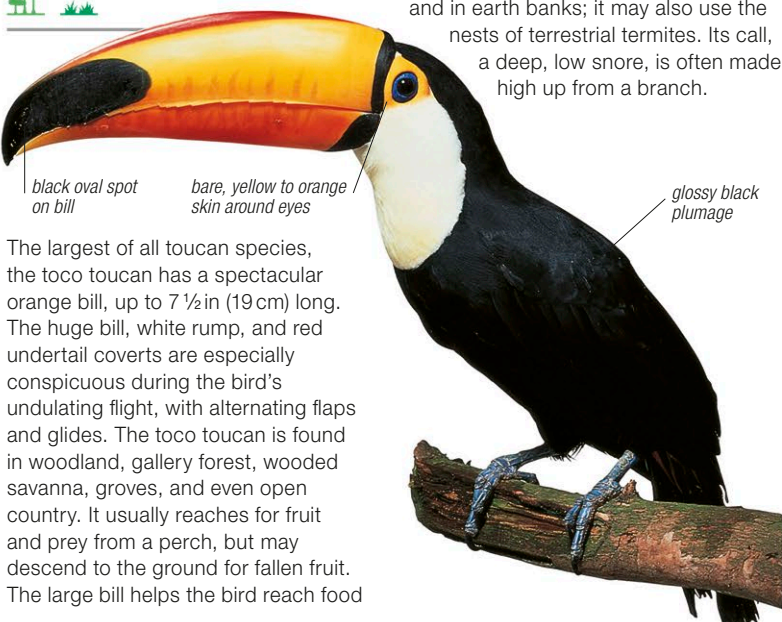
Ramphastos toco

Toco toucan



Location N.E. to C. South America

Length 21–23½ in (53–60 cm)
Weight 20 oz (550 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



black oval spot on bill

bare, yellow to orange skin around eyes

glossy black plumage

The largest of all toucan species, the toco toucan has a spectacular orange bill, up to 7 ½ in (19 cm) long. The huge bill, white rump, and red undertail coverts are especially conspicuous during the bird’s undulating flight, with alternating flaps and glides. The toco toucan is found in woodland, gallery forest, wooded savanna, groves, and even open country. It usually reaches for fruit and prey from a perch, but may descend to the ground for fallen fruit. The large bill helps the bird reach food

on the end of thin twigs that cannot support its weight. Once collected, food has to be moved from the tip of the bill into the bird’s throat—a task that is achieved with a quick backward toss of the head. Less sociable than other toucans, this bird sometimes participates in periodic invasions of new areas, which occur in certain years. It also migrates locally during some winters. The toco toucan makes its nest in existing holes in dead or living trees and in earth banks; it may also use the nests of terrestrial termites. Its call, a deep, low snore, is often made high up from a branch.

Jynx torquilla

Eurasian wryneck

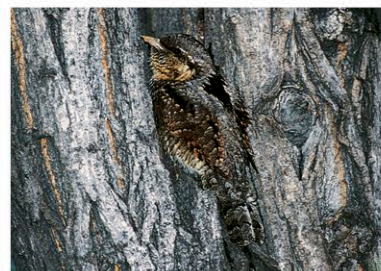


Location Europe to Asia, N. Africa

Length 6½ in (16 cm)
Weight ¾ oz (10 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



The Eurasian wryneck derives its name from its habit of twisting and writhing its neck, in snakelike fashion, as a form of defensive display. The speckled, brown, gray, buff, and white plumage camouflages it well against bark and the ground. It feeds on the larvae and pupae of ants, opening ant hills with its bill and using its sticky tongue to pick up its food.



Picumnus cirratus

White-barred piculet



Location N.E. and C. South America

Length 4 in (10 cm)
Weight ¾ oz (10 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Piculets (about 30 species) are the smallest members of the woodpecker family. Unlike typical woodpeckers, they do not use their tails to brace themselves against trees. The white-barred piculet has a short, soft tail and brownish gray plumage, the male having a distinctive red crown. Found in a wide variety of habitats, including open woodland, savanna, brush, and forest edges, it forages at low heights on thin twigs, vines, and bamboo. This tiny bird feeds on small insects, getting most of its food by vigorous hammering. It nests and roosts in holes in dead branches.

